Losers, Delegation, and the Ideological Valence of Expertise: Evidence from Finland

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Abstract

Research on partisan-motivated tolerance of democratic transgressions shows that voters often trade democratic procedures for partisan ends, weakening electoral checks on incumbents. Much less is known about how citizens evaluate delegation<U+2014>shifting authority from elected politicians to unelected experts. We address this gap with a simple formal model and new evidence from Finland. In the model, voters weigh a perceived performance gain from technocratic rule against ideological distance from government and the loss of electoral accountability. We argue that resistance to technocratic delegation concentrates in a subset of voters who perceive expert bodies as government-aligned. The model yields three implications: (i) support for delegation declines monotonically with distance from the governing coalition when expert institutions are perceived as aligned; (ii) this negative relationship attenuates when experts are viewed as neutral (or closer to the voter than the government) and steepens when alignment is high; and (iii) an irreversibility cost from ceding electoral control uniformly depresses support. Empirically, we analyze a novel 2025 survey of Finnish adults<U+2014>a high-capacity, multiparty parliamentary democracy and thus a hard case for partisan resistance to expertise. We develop an individual-level, seat-weighted measure of distance to the governing coalition based on party-closeness evaluations. Statistical models show that voters farther from the right-leaning Finnish cabinet are less supportive of delegation; results replicate with different measurements. Substantively, losers' consent to technocracy is conditional: delegation is acceptable primarily when performance gains outweigh ideological and accountability costs and when expert bodies are not seen as aligned with incumbents.

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PLEASE DO NOT CIRCULATE.

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1 Losers, Experts, and Accountability

Democracy rarely dies to the sound of tanks; it fades behind legalese, "independent commissions," and crisis cabinets staffed by experts. In Finland, the COVID–19 pandemic made this trade-off vivid: trust in public health authorities and scientific advisers was high on average, yet a subset of voters—disproportionately out-partisans—grew skeptical when expert guidance arrived alongside the government's agenda. Other notable examples are when, in polarized electorates, citizens often swallow anti-liberal moves when their side benefits (Svolik 2020; Svolik 2019). Classic work links electoral competition and cleavage structure to regime vulnerability (Sartori 1976; Dahl 1971; Lipset 1981), while contemporary research shows how incumbents tilt the field without canceling elections (Levitsky and Way 2010; Bermeo 2016; Waldner and Lust 2018). Our paper pushes this literature one step earlier in the causal chain and asks: *when do voters prefer the steady hand of "experts" over the rough justice of elections?* While oppositions often support strengthening checks as political insurance against executive overreach (Capoccia 2007), our claim is narrower: a *subset* of voters resists technocratic delegation when expert bodies are perceived as government-aligned. This scope condition shifts the focus from aggregate trust in experts to partisan perceptions of alignment, explaining why technocratic delegation polarizes electoral losers.

Our contribution is twofold. Theoretically, we develop a simple formal model in which voters weigh a performance advantage from technocratic rule against ideological loss and diminished accountability; the model predicts that support for delegation falls with ideological distance from the governing bloc when experts are perceived as government-aligned. Empirically, we analyze a new 2025 survey of adults in Finland—a high-capacity, multiparty parliamentary democracy and thus a hard case where expert governance might otherwise be broadly acceptable. Even in this consensual, high-trust context, support for democratic norms is conditional. For example, Saikkonen and Christensen (2023) find that a subset of voters tolerates transgressions by ideologically congruent leaders, while disaffected citizens sanction less. Related Finnish evidence shows that support for technocratic decision-making concentrates among respondents who view "ordinary citizens" as less competent, whereas confidence in fellow citizens tilts preferences toward representative or participatory channels (Rapeli and Von Schoultz 2023). Together, the theory and the empirical evidence recenter debates about backsliding on a neglected choice: not just whether citizens punish rule-breaking (*à la* Svolik (2020) and Svolik (2019)), but whether they are willing to *outsource* rule-making in the first place. Ultimately, our approach bridges elite–centric accounts of backsliding, which stress supply and cueing (Bartels 2023), with demand–side realism about voter cognition (Achen and Bartels 2016). We study a concrete instantiation of the broader tension between popular sovereignty and liberal constraints (Mounk 2018): when do citizens prefer delegation to unelected experts over electoral accountability?

Our core claim is that delegation is *ideologically valenced*. When technocrats are perceived as aligned with incumbent parties, electoral losers may resist delegating authority away from elected politicians even if they support checks and balances. We formalize this intuition with a simple voter-choice model in which individuals compare the expected performance advantage from technocratic rule to the ideological loss from ceding control. The model yields three testable implications that guide our empirics. First, support for delegation falls monotonically with a voter's ideological distance from the governing coalition when experts are perceived as government-aligned: delegation is chosen only if the expected performance advantage benefit exceeds (the squared) ideological loss. Second, this negative effects attenuates when experts are perceived as neutral (or closer to the voter than the government), and steepens when experts are seen as closely aligned with incumbents. Third, an irreversibility cost associated with losing electoral control (a loss of accountability) uniformly depresses support for delegation, tightening the threshold for all voters.

The paper also finds empirical support for our theoretical expectations. We exploit a novel survey of adults in Finland. Respondents reported closeness to each parliamentary party; these evaluations were combined into a respondent-level proximity to the governing coalition by weighting coalition parties by their parliamentary seat shares and renormalizing weights over the parties each respondent rated. The proximity measure was transformed into a normalized distance-to-government index. Consistent with the model's first implication, results show a clear negative association between distance from the governing coalition and support for delegation. In line with the second implication, the relationship weakens when institutions are perceived as less ideologically aligned and strengthens among respondents with stronger partisan attachments or in more polarized environments. The third implication is reflected in lower average support for delegation among respondents expressing greater concern with democratic accountability. The pattern is robust to alternative distance constructions (seat–weighted, unweighted, closest–party) and to modeling choices. Taken together, the formal model clarifies the mechanism—delegation is acceptable only when the expected performance advantage outweighs ideological and accountability losses—and the evidence aligns with this logic: losers in Finland prefer electoral accountability over technocratic delegation when expert authority is perceived as aligned with the incumbent.

Finland is a demanding case for our argument. It is a high-capacity, consensus-oriented polity where trust in public institutions and expertise is generally high. Precisely for that reason, it helps isolate heterogeneities in how citizens evaluate delegation, potentially increasing the inferential leverage of our findings. Our claim is not that Finns view experts as partisan in the aggregate, but that a *subset of voters*—especially those far from the governing coalition—infer alignment when expert bodies advise, are appointed by, or implement the agenda of incumbents. Anecdotal evidence from the COVID-19 period illustrates this pattern: despite high average trust, confidence in official expert guidance varied by party sympathy, with skepticism concentrated among out-partisans while co-partisans remained supportive. In our framework, such heterogeneities matter because these voters evaluate delegation as a trade-off: a perceived governance-quality gain versus an ideological loss and reduced electoral accountability. The formal model makes this mechanism explicit and yields the core prediction we test: even in a high-trust environment, support for delegation declines with ideological distance from government when experts are perceived as government-aligned; the effect attenuates when experts are seen as neutral; and it is uniformly lower when the loss of accountability looms large. Finland therefore allows us to show that the observed pattern is driven by a subset of voters rather than by generalized anti-expert sentiment. Finally, our question sits at the intersection of realist views of mass politics (Achen and Bartels 2016) and critiques of the administrative/technocratic state (Hamburger 2014; Glennon 2014; Majone 1994): when, and for which *subset of voters*, does delegating authority to unelected experts substitute for electoral accountability rather than complement it?

2 When Expertise Is Perceived as Partisan

Democratic governance typically balances technocratic delegation against democratic accountability. Technocratic delegation refers to entrusting policy authority to experts or non-partisan institutions insulated from direct electoral control. Examples include independent central banks, regulatory agencies, or constitutional courts staffed by specialists. Such delegation is justified by the promise of neutral competence and long-term policy stability, but it inherently trades off responsiveness to the electorate. In other words, empowering the experts may improve technocratic quality at the cost of reducing the public's direct say in decision-making (Caramani 2017). This tension is well documented: technocratic policy-making can dilute traditional accountability, since decisions

occur outside the arena of partisan competition and popular oversight (Bertsou and Caramani 2020). Democratic accountability, by contrast, requires that those who make policy are answerable to voters through elections and representative institutions. The crux of the issue is that what incumbents defend as neutral expertise, electoral losers may perceive as unaccountable elite rule. Importantly, institutional independence need not imply neutrality. Demand for delegation is heterogeneous along non-ideological lines as well: attitudes toward technocracy co-vary with beliefs about mass competence, providing micro-foundations for why only a *subset of voters* accepts expert rule even in high-trust contexts (Rapeli and Von Schoultz 2023).

Evidence from U.S. monetary policy shows that an ostensibly technocratic, insulated actor like the Federal Reserve can be "independent but not indifferent," exhibiting partisan responsiveness as a *conditional inflation hawk* that shifts policy in ways benefiting one partisan bloc (Clark and Arel-Bundock 2013). This underscores our core claim: delegation can acquire an ideological valence that voters perceive and react to. A central implication of our theory is that electoral losers' consent to delegation hinges on whether nominally "neutral" institutions are *perceived* as impartial or as aligned agents of the winners. While oppositions often support strengthening checks as political insurance against executive overreach (Capoccia 2007), our claim is narrower: a *subset of voters* resists technocratic delegation when expert bodies are seen as government-aligned, even as they endorse judicial or oversight constraints.

Losers' consent is crucial for democratic stability: those who lose an election must still accept the legitimacy of the system and trust that their interests will be protected in opposition (Anderson et al. 2005). Typically, this is easier when independent institutions (courts, oversight bodies, expert agencies) serve as credible guardians of fair play. However, when losers suspect that these institutions are in fact partisan—stacked with or naturally sympathetic to the incumbent coalition's ideology—their willingness to consent to delegation plummets. In effect, the losers no longer regard technocratic bodies as neutral arbiters but rather as extensions of the ruling bloc. Delegation under these conditions appears to them as a circumvention of democracy: policy being set by unelected actors who covertly advance the incumbents' program. Losers will thus resist ceding authority to such bodies, invoking the need for accountability and the "will of the people" to counter what they view as a biased technocracy.

Our argument is grounded in several streams of research. First, in polarized polities, even nominally non-partisan institutions become perceived in partisan terms. Polarization—the deep ideological divide between political camps—undermines any shared baseline of trust in institutions. Svolik (2019) demonstrates that intense polarization "undermines the public's ability to serve as a democratic check," as voters become willing to trade off democratic principles for partisan interests. In such an environment, each side suspects that ostensibly neutral referees (be it the judiciary, civil service, or expert regulators) covertly favor their opponents. Empirically, attitudes toward democratic institutions themselves have grown increasingly sorted by partisan identity. Claassen et al. (2025), for example, show that in countries led by right-wing populists (Hungary, Poland, Brazil), supporters of the incumbent right exhibit markedly lower support for liberal-democratic checks and balances, whereas the opposing camp (the electoral losers) places greater value on those checks. The key insight is that polarization produces mirror-image perceptions: *winners may dismiss certain constraints as nuisances, while losers champion them—but only so long as they believe those institutions can constrain the ruling side.* If instead the institutions are seen as captured by the ruling side, this pattern flips. Under hyper-polarization, institutions that should function as neutral checks are readily turned into, or at least seen as, unaccountable instruments of partisan or incumbent advantage. In the words of Lieberman et al. (2019, p. 471), polarization magnifies the partisan capture of independent institutions, eroding their legitimacy as neutral arbiters.

Given this dynamic, electoral losers will oppose technocratic delegation particularly when expert

bodies carry an ideological valence aligned with incumbents. By ideological valence of expertise, we mean that expert institutions are not *perceived* as ideologically neutral but instead as tilting toward one end of the political spectrum. Expertise is never exercised in a political vacuum: economic technocrats, for instance, may predominantly subscribe to market-liberal orthodoxy (Clark and Arel-Bundock 2013; Clark, Golder, and Poast 2013); legal and bureaucratic elites might share the social outlook of the incumbent regime; scientific experts might prioritize values associated with one side of the cultural divide. In highly polarized contexts, these associations become highly salient. Losers come to view the "independent" central bank as effectively partisan (e.g. favoring austerity aligned with the government's ideology), or the judiciary as packed with judges loyal to the ruling party. As a result, what might superficially be a technocratic policy—say, an impartial public-health directive or a monetary tightening—is interpreted through a partisan lens. Perceived ideological bias in technocratic institutions thus short-circuits losers' trust. Rather than seeing delegation as securing unbiased expertise, losers see it as entrenching the incumbent coalition's preferences behind a facade of objectivity.

Moreover, partisans often apply a double standard to "neutral" oversight: support for procedural checks is highest when those checks constrain the out-party and softens when they constrain co-partisans (Svolik 2019; Kingzette et al. 2021). This contingency is consistent with the realist view that group identity and performance considerations, rather than abstract proceduralism, structure mass attitudes (Achen and Bartels 2016). In short, both winners and losers tend to champion institutional checks when those checks serve their partisan interests and to discount them when they do not. This pattern implies that an electoral loser's professed demand for accountability may mask a concern with policy outcomes: when their side is out of power, they are most likely to decry "unelected bureaucrats" or "activist judges" when those actors are perceived as aligned with the rival camp. Our theory links this demand-side asymmetry to work on democratic backsliding: just as incumbents may erode checks to entrench power, oppositions can withdraw support from institutions they deem compromised. In both cases, commitment to democratic rules becomes contingent on who controls the levers of state authority (Waldner and Lust 2018).

We argue that opposition to technocratic delegation will be most acute under two conditions. First, when political polarization and partisan identity are strong. In a polarized environment, mutual mistrust runs high and even independent institutions are painted in red or blue. High affective partisan identification means citizens are less likely to tolerate policies made outside electoral contest, since compromise with the other side might be seen as a loss. Under such polarization, the basic requirement for losers' consent—confidence that the system treats sides fairly—is in short supply. Second, when incumbents have in fact politicized or captured nominally technocratic institutions. Incumbent governments frequently use appointments and institutional reforms to bias ostensibly independent bodies in their favor, especially during episodes of democratic backsliding (Lührmann and Lindberg 2019). Examples abound: packing supreme courts, tilting election commissions, staffing central bank boards with ideologically like-minded experts. These actions do not go unnoticed by the opposition. On the contrary, they become focal points of political conflict. An opposition that sees, say, the electoral commission openly favoring the ruling party will stridently object to any further empowerment of that commission. In new or fragile democracies, losing parties sometimes even refuse to recognize referees (for example, boycotting a biased election commission or constitutional court) precisely because they view them as tools of the incumbents. Thus, where the integrity of technocratic institutions is compromised, losers respond by rejecting those institutions' authority.

Importantly, our theory does not claim that electoral losers inherently oppose expert rule *per se*. Rather, the support or opposition of losers toward technocratic delegation is conditional on the perceived neutrality of expertise relative to partisan competition. In contexts where expert

institutions are broadly trusted across the spectrum, losers may willingly delegate decisions to them—indeed, historically, opposition parties often support strengthening independent authorities as a way to constrain powerful executives (Keefer and Stasavage 2003). Likewise, survey evidence suggests that citizens who feel alienated from partisan politics (i.e., "structural losers") can exhibit higher support for technocratic governance as an alternative to dysfunctional party competition (Bertsou and Caramani 2020). However, those scenarios presume that expertise stands apart from partisan ideology. Our contribution is to theorize what happens when that presumption breaks down. When expertise is perceived as ideologically aligned, delegation no longer offers a neutral solution. To the contrary, it appears as a mechanism for the ruling coalition to lock in its preferences without democratic contest. Under such conditions, we predict that electoral losers will frame technocratic delegation as illegitimate and resist it. They will call instead for decisions to be returned to "the people" (often via elections or referendums) where the opposition has a fighting chance. In short, when expert institutions are ideologically aligned with incumbents, opposition actors interpret technocratic delegation as partisan entrenchment and respond by reasserting democratic accountability through popular control.

This theoretical logic yields several observable implications. We would expect, for instance, that losers' resistance to delegation is heightened in highly polarized, ideologically sorted party systems, and during periods of intense policy conflict between government and opposition. Indeed, our framework helps explain why populist movements (often composed of "losers" of globalization or of recent elections) frequently target technocratic institutions as part of a corrupt establishment (Caramani 2017). Conversely, in consensus-oriented or depolarized settings, or where technocratic bodies enjoy cross-partisan legitimacy, we should see less of this loser's backlash. Ultimately, our theory underscores a paradox of contemporary democracy: institutions designed as impartial checks can sustain democratic stability only if they are broadly seen as impartial. If they come to be viewed as the ideological instruments of those in power, the very actors who most need to accept them—the electoral losers—may withdraw their consent, imperiling the delicate balance between expertise and democracy.

3 A Voter's Trade-Off: Technocratic Delegation vs. Electoral Accountability

Consider a one–dimensional policy space $[0, 1]$. A voter i has ideal point $\theta_i \in [0, 1]$. The governing coalition ("government") has position $\theta_g \in [0, 1]$. A technocratic institution ("experts") has perceived position $\theta_e \in [0, 1]$.

Distance and alignment. Define voter–government distance

$$d_i \;\equiv\; |\theta_i - \theta_g| \in [0, 1],$$

which corresponds to our empirical measure `Government distance`. Perceived expert *alignment* with government is summarized by $\alpha \in [0, 1]$ via

$$\theta_e(\alpha) \;=\; \alpha\,\theta_g + (1 - \alpha)\,\bar{\theta},$$

where $\bar{\theta}$ is a non–partisan reference (e.g., a technocratic consensus or the median policy). Full alignment means $\alpha = 1$ (so $\theta_e = \theta_g$); lower α implies more neutral experts.

Sequence. Voter i chooses between retaining *electoral accountability* (A) or *delegating* to experts (D). Under D, policy is set at $\theta_e(\alpha)$ by unelected experts. Under A, electoral control ultimately delivers policy responsive to voters. For tractability, we take the long–run accountable outcome for voter i as $\theta_A = \theta_i$.[1]

Preferences. Utility is spatial with a technocratic valence gain $B \geq 0$ and an irreversibility (or loss–of–accountability) penalty $\lambda \geq 0$ under delegation:

$$U_i(A) = -(\theta_i - \theta_A)^2 \;=\; 0,$$
$$U_i(D) = -(\theta_i - \theta_e(\alpha))^2 \;+\; B \;-\; \lambda.$$

Here B captures expected performance advantage from experts; λ captures the asymmetric difficulty of reversing delegation (loss of electoral control).

Decision rule. Voter i supports delegation iff $U_i(D) > U_i(A)$, i.e.

$$B \;-\; \lambda \;>\; \big(\theta_i - \theta_e(\alpha)\big)^2. \tag{1}$$

Equivalently, define the *required valence* for delegation,

$$B_i^\star(\alpha, \lambda) \;\equiv\; \lambda + \big(\theta_i - \theta_e(\alpha)\big)^2,$$

so that D is chosen iff $B > B_i^\star$.

Special case: fully aligned experts. If $\alpha = 1$ (experts perceived as government–aligned), then $\theta_e = \theta_g$ and

$$B \;-\; \lambda \;>\; d_i^2. \tag{2}$$

Hence delegation is strictly decreasing in d_i: distant ("loser") voters require larger B to accept delegation.

Comparative statics.

- **Distance effect.** For fixed (B, λ, α), delegation is (weakly) less likely as d_i grows. Under Equation 2, the threshold is $d_i^\star(B, \lambda) = \sqrt{B - \lambda}$; if $d_i > d_i^\star$, voter i rejects delegation.
- **Valence effect.** For fixed (d_i, λ, α), delegation is more likely as B increases; $\partial \mathbf{1}\{D\}/\partial B \geq 0$.
- **Irreversibility.** For fixed (d_i, B, α), delegation is less likely as λ increases; $\partial \mathbf{1}\{D\}/\partial \lambda \leq 0$.
- **Perceived alignment.** Since $\theta_e(\alpha) = \alpha\theta_g + (1 - \alpha)\bar{\theta}$, the ideological loss under D is $L_i(\alpha) \equiv (\theta_i - \theta_e(\alpha))^2$. If $\bar{\theta}$ lies weakly between θ_g and θ_i, then $L_i(\alpha)$ is (weakly) increasing in α; delegation becomes less likely as experts are perceived more aligned with government.

[1] A more general formulation lets $\theta_A = \phi\,\theta_i + (1 - \phi)\,\theta_g$ with $\phi \in (0, 1]$ measuring accountability effectiveness. All results below go through with $(\theta_i - \theta_e)^2$ replaced by $(\theta_i - \theta_e)^2 - (\theta_i - \theta_A)^2$.

Propositions.

1. **Losers oppose aligned technocracy.** If $\alpha = 1$, there exists a cutoff $d_i^\star(B, \lambda) = \sqrt{B - \lambda}$ such that voter i supports delegation iff $d_i < d_i^\star$. Thus, for any fixed (B, λ) with $B > \lambda$, support for delegation is strictly decreasing in d_i.

2. **Neutral experts attenuate the distance penalty.** If $\alpha < 1$ and $\bar{\theta}$ is closer to θ_i than θ_g is, then $L_i(\alpha) < d_i^2$, so the required valence $B_i^\star(\alpha, \lambda)$ falls relative to the aligned case. Opposition voters may accept delegation when experts are perceived neutral, holding (B, λ) fixed.

3. **Asymmetry tightens the threshold.** For any $(\theta_i, \theta_g, \alpha)$ and B, there exists $\bar{\lambda}$ such that for all $\lambda \geq \bar{\lambda}$, Equation 1 fails and voter i rejects delegation. Greater irreversibility (loss of electoral control) systematically depresses support for delegation.

Link to identification. Equation 2 delivers the empirical prediction that, when expert institutions are perceived as government–aligned, *support for delegation is decreasing in the normalized distance* d_i and increasing in perceived valence B, with attenuation when experts are viewed as neutral ($\alpha < 1$) and when λ is small. This maps one–for–one to our econometric specification with `Government distance` as the main covariate and measures of institutional trust/competence as proxies for (B, α).

4 Data and Findings

4.1 Measurement

The main independent variable is `Government distance`, a respondent–government distance measure based on party–closeness ratings.

Let i index respondents and let $p \in G$ index parties in the governing coalition. Survey respondents rated their closeness to each parliamentary party on a 0–10 scale. Let $C_{ip} \in [0, 10]$ denote respondent i's closeness to party p. Let s_p be party p's seat count in the *Eduskunta* (the Finnish Parliament) at the time of fieldwork,[2] and define coalition seat weights

$$w_p \equiv \frac{s_p}{\sum_{q \in G} s_q}. \tag{3}$$

Due to missingness, weights were renormalized over the set of parties that respondent i rated:

$$\tilde{w}_{ip} \equiv \frac{w_p \, \mathbb{1}\{C_{ip} \text{ observed}\}}{\sum_{q \in G} w_q \, \mathbb{1}\{C_{iq} \text{ observed}\}}. \tag{4}$$

Then, seat–weighted coalition closeness is

$$\texttt{Government closeness}_i \equiv \sum_{p \in G} \tilde{w}_{ip} \, C_{ip} \;\in\; [0, 10]. \tag{5}$$

We scaled it to $[0, 1]$ and defined the complementary distance index:

$$\texttt{Government distance}_i \equiv 1 - \frac{\texttt{Government closeness}_i}{10} \;\in\; [0, 1]. \tag{6}$$

By construction, larger $\texttt{Government distance}_i$ indicates greater distance from the governing coalition.

[2] KOK = 48, PS = 46, RKP = 9, KD = 5.

Beyond the seat–weighted baseline in Equation 6, we also construct two conceptually adjacent indices. First, an *unweighted* coalition proximity treats each governing party symmetrically, abstracting from parliamentary strength and thereby reducing dependence on the specific seat distribution at fieldwork. Let

$$\texttt{Government closeness (UW)}_i \;\equiv\; \frac{\sum_{p\in G} C_{ip}\,\mathbb{1}\{C_{ip}\text{ observed}\}}{\sum_{q\in G}\mathbb{1}\{C_{iq}\text{ observed}\}} \;\in\; [0,10], \tag{A1}$$

with `NA` if no governing party was rated. The associated distance is

$$\texttt{Government distance (UW)}_i \;\equiv\; 1 - \frac{\texttt{Government closeness (UW)}_i}{10} \;\in\; [0,1]. \tag{7}$$

Second, a *closest–party* distance captures the heuristic that respondents may anchor evaluations on the single governing party they feel closest to (salience of a primary partisan tie), and it is maximally robust to selective answering:

$$\texttt{Government distance (Closest)}_i \;\equiv\; 1 - \frac{\max_{p\in G} C_{ip}}{10} \;\in\; [0,1], \tag{8}$$

set to `NA` when all C_{ip} for $p \in G$ are missing.

Taken together, the seat–weighted (Equation 6), unweighted (Equation 7), and closest–party (Equation 8) indices map, respectively, to influence–weighted proximity to the governing bloc, an equal–party aggregation, and a strongest–affinity anchor. We use all three in the empirical analysis; as shown below, they yield substantively similar patterns, indicating that our results do not hinge on a particular distance construction or on the treatment of item nonresponse.

4.2 Estimation Strategy

We estimated the association between support for technocratic delegation (`Technocracy`) and ideological distance from the governing coalition (`Government distance`) using a linear specification. Now, let $\texttt{Technocracy}_i$ denote respondent i's technocracy item and $\texttt{Government distance}_i$ the normalized index in Equation 6.[3]

For expositional clarity we use the seat–weighted index as our primary measure, since it mirrors parties' relative bargaining power within the cabinet and thus the theoretical object of interest—proximity to the governing bloc as policy setter. It also tempers noise from idiosyncratic ratings of very small coalition partners with limited agenda influence. For robustness, we re–estimate all models with the unweighted aggregation (Equation 7) and the closest–party anchor (Equation 8); the results are substantively unchanged (Table A1). The baseline model is

[3]We treated the 1–5 outcome variable as approximately continuous (ordered models are reported as robustness in Table A2, yielding substantively identical conclusions). The survey question asked (originally in Finnish) "What do you think about the following statements? [...] Our country would work better if political decisions were left to independent, non-elected experts instead of politicians." The options were "Strongly disagree" (n=133), "Somewhat disagree" (n=248), "Neither agree nor disagree" (n=383), "Somewhat agree" (n=436) and "Totally agree" (n=197).

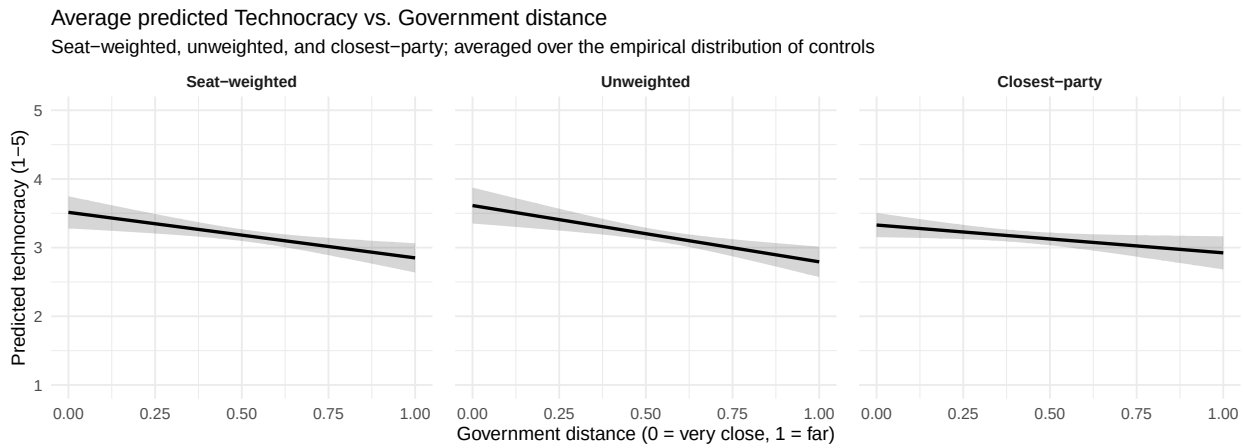

Figure 1: Average predicted, technocracy vs. government distance (95% CIs).

$$
\begin{aligned}
\texttt{Technocracy}_i \; &= \beta_0 \\
&+ \; \beta_1 \, \texttt{Government distance}_i \\
&+ \; \beta_2 \, \texttt{Democratic satisfaction}_i \\
&+ \; \beta_3 \, \texttt{Trust in politicians}_i \\
&+ \; \boldsymbol{\gamma}' \, \mathbf{X}_i \\
&+ \; \delta_{\text{region}(i)} \\
&+ \; \varepsilon_i
\end{aligned}
\tag{9}
$$

where $\mathbf{X}_i$ includes education, age, and gender, and $\delta_{\text{region}(i)}$ are region fixed effects. The coefficient of interest is β_1, which—under the formal model's assumptions—should be negative when expert institutions are perceived as aligned with the incumbent bloc.

4.3 Results

Figure 1 plots marginal-standardized (average) predictions of `Technocracy` across the full range of `Government distance`; the solid line is the point estimate and the band the 95% CI. Across all three panels—seat–weighted, unweighted, and closest-party—the relationship is monotonically negative: moving from full proximity to maximal distance lowered the predicted score from roughly 3.5 to about 2.8 on the 1-5 scale. The near-identical slope in the unweighted panel shows that the pattern did not hinge on coalition seat shares or renormalization, while the closest-party panel reproduced the same decline with slightly wider intervals at the extremes.

In light of our voter-choice framework, these estimates align with the mechanism in which ideological loss grows with distance while the performance gains and the accountability cost are held fixed. As `Government distance` widens, the term $(\theta_i - \theta_e)^2$ increases, so fewer respondents satisfy the delegation condition $B - \lambda > (\theta_i - \theta_e)^2$. Substantively, the slope moved the average respondent from slight technocratic sympathy toward skepticism as distance increased.

Although the survey did not directly ask whether experts were perceived as ideologically biased, the gradient in Figure 1 is unlikely to be an artifact of measurement or data aggregation, suggesting that experts were not viewed as uniformly neutral. The pattern implies that a nontrivial share of respondents inferred some alignment between expert bodies and the right-leaning cabinet, which

depressed willingness to delegate among those farthest from the government in ideological space. At the same time, these results do not suggest that Finnish voters, on average, saw experts as politicized. We believe that Finland's high baseline of institutional trust coexists with different heterogeneity levels: a considerable ammount of respondents likely trusted experts, while others—disproportionately opposition-aligned voters—appeared more sensitive to who would be empowered and who appointed them.

The near-parallel slopes across the seat-weighted, unweighted, and closest-party panels, together with ordered-logit estimates that treat the outcome as ordinal (Table A2), indicate that the core association is not an artifact of proximity aggregation or outcome scaling.

5 Discussion and Limitations

This study argued that citizens evaluated technocratic delegation through an ideologically valenced lens. We formalized a voter's choice as a trade-off between a perceived performance gain from expert rule, the ideological loss from ceding authority to actors aligned with the incumbent coalition, and an accountability (irreversibility) cost. The model yielded three central implications: support for delegation decreased with ideological distance from government when experts were perceived as aligned; this distance penalty attenuated when experts were viewed as neutral; and higher accountability costs uniformly depressed support. Empirically, we analyzed a novel Finnish survey and constructed respondent-level distances to the governing coalition using seat-weighted party-closeness, alongside unweighted and closest-party variants. Linear and ordered-logit models consistently indicated a monotonic, negative association between distance and support for delegation. Average predicted values declined across the full distance range and the pattern replicated under alternative distance constructions, supporting the model's core comparative statics.

The findings were especially noteworthy because Finland constituted a demanding case. Finland reliably ranked very high on institutional trust, and large shares of the public trusted government, civil service, and the broader expert community. In such a context, technocratic delegation would have been expected to be broadly acceptable across partisan lines. Instead, support appeared conditional on perceived alignment: voters ideologically distant from the right-leaning cabinet expressed lower willingness to delegate. This pattern was consistent with the idea that, even in a high-trust polity, a nontrivial segment of the electorate inferred that experts could lean toward the incumbents, thereby activating a partisan calculus. At the same time, the results did not imply that all Finns viewed experts as politicized. Taken together, we find that technocratic delegation was endorsed when the performance gains outweighed ideological and accountability losses.

These results come with several. First, we did not directly measure respondents' perceptions of expert alignment or ideological bias. The inference that perceived alignment mattered rested on behavioral patterns (lower delegation support among those farther from government) rather than on explicit survey questions. This limitation implied caution in interpreting the mechanism; future work would benefit from direct measures of perceived neutrality, appointment trust, and agency ideology. Second, the design was observational and cross-sectional, so we could not fully preclude omitted-variable bias or reverse causality (e.g., low support for delegation shaping ex post evaluations of distance). We mitigated this risk with control variables and alternative distance constructions, but stronger identification—via panel data, event-study designs around cabinet changes or salient appointments, or experiments—would have improved causal leverage.

Third, our distance measure relied on self-reported party-closeness and seat-share weights as a proxy for influence within the cabinet. Nonresponse patterns and measurement error in closeness ratings could introduce noise, and seat weights might imperfectly map onto perceived agenda

power. We partially addressed this by reporting unweighted and closest-party variants, which delivered substantively similar results, but additional weighting schemes should be explored in future research. Fourth, the technocracy outcome was a single ordered item. Although results were robust to ordered-logit specifications, single-item measures are vulnerable to wording effects or scale interpretation. A multi-item battery tapping distinct facets, such as views about democratic accountability and attitudes toward different government bodies—would yield a more reliable latent construct.

Fifth, while Finland served as a strong hard test, external validity beyond high-trust, consensus-oriented democracies remained uncertain. The same mechanism could be stronger where baseline trust was lower and polarization higher, but it could also interact with other macro-level variables. Finally, our analyses focused on attitudes; thus, behavioral implications remained to be established.

Several extensions follow. First, future surveys should directly measure perceived expert alignment and credibility of appointment procedures (e.g., transparent vs. partisan selection), and incorporate items that separately capture the performance gains and the accountability cost. Experimental vignettes could randomize expert appointment rules, explicit ideological signals, and evidence of performance, allowing a clean test of the model's thresholds. Second, designs that exploit temporal variation—before/after cabinet reshuffles, high-salience appointments, or prominent policy episodes—would sharpen causal inference. Third, comparative designs could improve inferential leverage by testing whether the negative effect of government distance on support for delegation intensifies when perceived alignment is more salient and accountability costs loom larger. Fourth, within-country heterogeneity deserves closer attention: multilevel models with party or region random slopes, and explicit tests of the distance effect within parties, would clarify whether the mechanism operated similarly among government supporters and among different strands of the opposition. Finally, linking attitudes to behavior—support for institutional reforms, willingness to cede authority in specific domains, or tolerance for curbing expert bodies—would shed light on the political consequences of ideologically valenced delegation.

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6 Appendix

6.1 Regression Models

Table A1: OLS Estimates: Technocracy and Business vs. Government Distance

	Tech: Seat-wt	Tech: Unwt	Tech: Closest	Biz: Seat-wt	Biz: Unwt	Biz: Closest
Constant	4.231***	4.357***	4.005***	4.055***	4.224***	3.649***
	(0.229)	(0.240)	(0.213)	(0.267)	(0.291)	(0.245)
Government distance (seat-weighted)	−0.663**			−1.850***		
	(0.216)			(0.219)		
Democratic satisfaction	−0.052*	−0.053*	−0.054*	−0.071**	−0.073**	−0.076**
	(0.026)	(0.026)	(0.026)	(0.027)	(0.027)	(0.027)
Trust in politicians	−0.071**	−0.074**	−0.065*	−0.041	−0.044+	−0.033
	(0.025)	(0.025)	(0.025)	(0.026)	(0.026)	(0.026)
Government distance (unweighted)		−0.820***			−2.051***	
		(0.234)			(0.253)	
Government distance (closest-party)			−0.405*			−1.454***
			(0.200)			(0.202)
Num.Obs.	689	689	689	703	703	703
R2	0.057	0.061	0.050	0.151	0.152	0.126
R2 Adj.	0.038	0.042	0.030	0.133	0.134	0.108
RMSE	1.12	1.12	1.13	1.18	1.18	1.19
Std.Errors	Tech: Seat-wt	Tech: Unwt	Tech: Closest	Biz: Seat-wt	Biz: Unwt	Biz: Closest
Education FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Age FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Gender	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Region FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes

Notes: HC1 robust standard errors in parentheses. Models include education, age, gender, and region fixed effects (omitted for brevity).

6.2 Business Plots

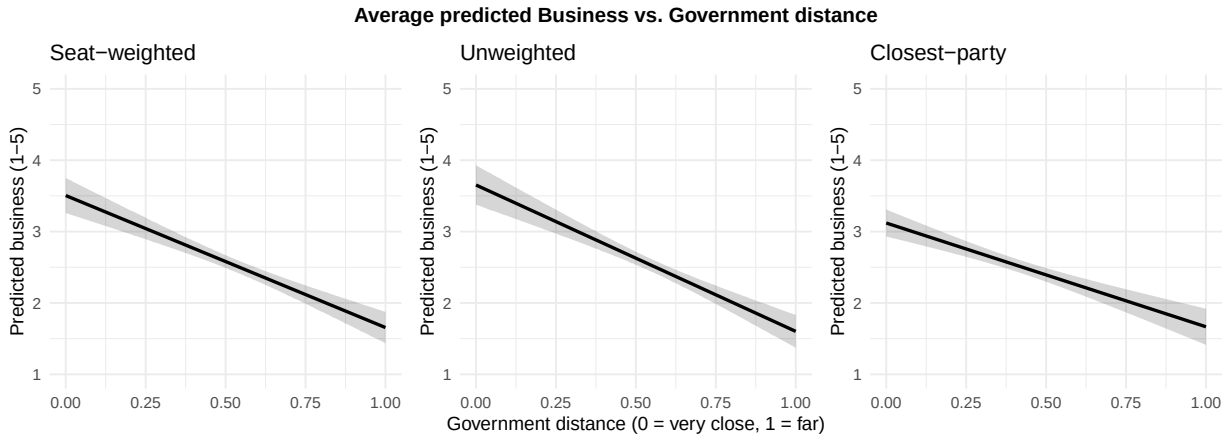

Figure A1: Average predicted, business vs. government distance (95% CIs).

6.3 Regression Table with Outcome Variable treated as Ordered

Table A2: Ordered logit (proportional odds) estimates: Technocracy and Business vs. Government Distance

	Tech (OL): Seat-wt	Tech (OL): Unwt	Tech (OL): Closest	Biz (OL): Seat-wt	Biz (OL): Unwt	Biz (OL): Closest
Government distance (seat-weighted)	−1.022**			−2.852***		
	(0.339)			(0.349)		
Democratic satisfaction	−0.084*	−0.085*	−0.087*	−0.113**	−0.116**	−0.116**
	(0.040)	(0.040)	(0.040)	(0.040)	(0.040)	(0.040)
Trust in politicians	−0.107**	−0.113**	−0.096*	−0.063	−0.070+	−0.050
	(0.039)	(0.039)	(0.039)	(0.039)	(0.039)	(0.038)
Government distance (unweighted)		−1.274***			−3.219***	
		(0.372)			(0.390)	
Government distance (closest-party)			−0.612*			−2.207***
			(0.311)			(0.318)
Num.Obs.	689	689	689	703	703	703
RMSE	3.18	3.18	3.18	2.65	2.65	2.65
Std.Errors	Tech (OL): Seat-wt	Tech (OL): Unwt	Tech (OL): Closest	Biz (OL): Seat-wt	Biz (OL): Unwt	Biz (OL): Closest
Education FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Age FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Gender	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Region FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes

Notes: Model-based standard errors in parentheses. Cutpoints omitted. Models include education, age, gender, and region fixed effects (omitted for brevity).

6.4 Technocratic Support by Party Choice

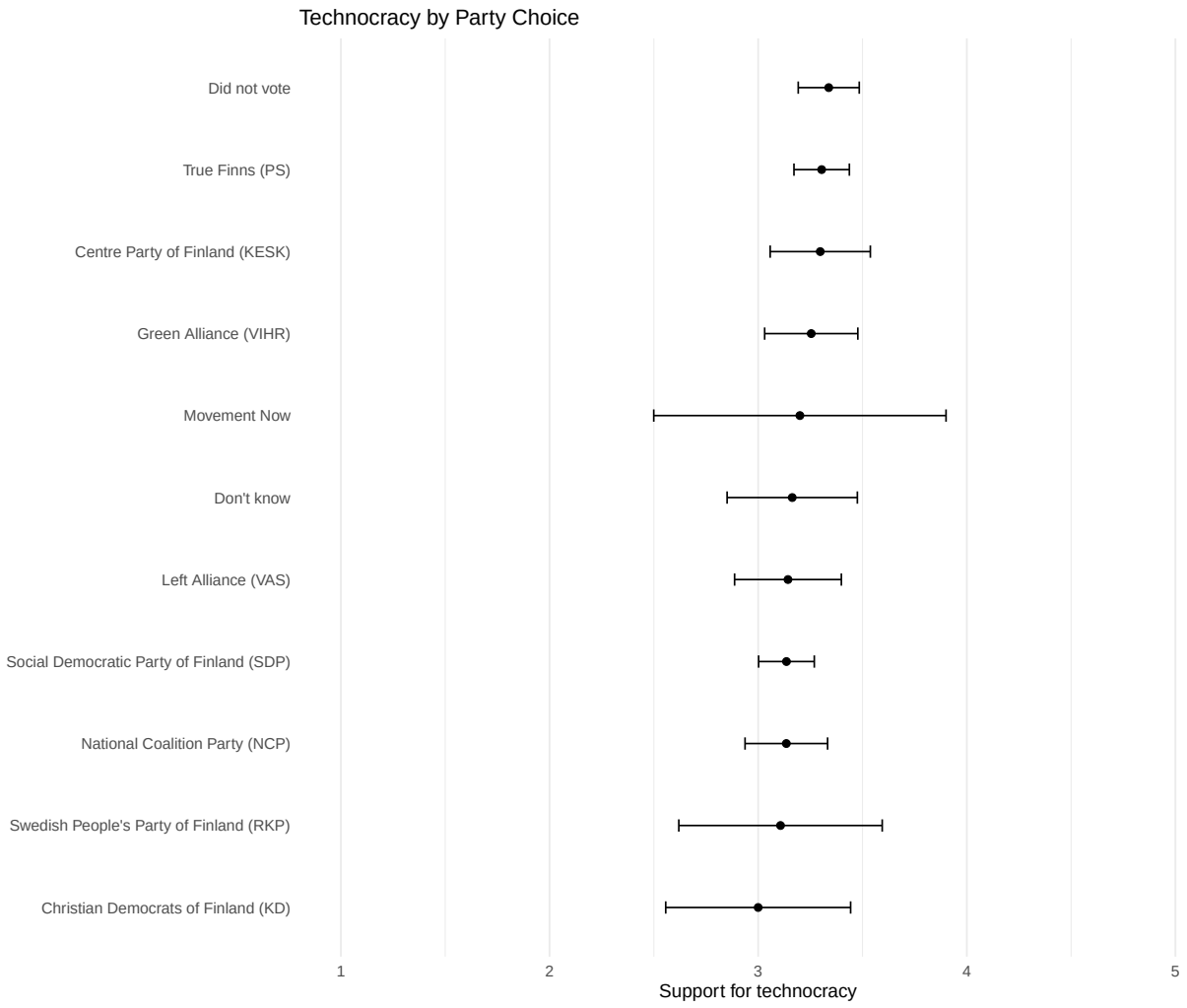

Figure A2: Technocracy by Party Choice (95% CIs).